The sensitivity to nurturing India's cultural footprint over the ages is now visible in focussed efforts to promote cooperation in heritage conservation. It is not just the rising metrics of power that count; it is also the accompanying cultural and intellectual resurrection that is key to global rebalancing. India matters on that account due to its unique contributions.

THE WORLD AS A FAMILY

If from the recesses of history there have emerged factors that enhance India's relevance, this could be the case for more contemporary periods as well. Here, too, the impediments were only in our own minds, conditioned by the politics of the day. Take the events of the last century. Indian contribution to both World Wars was significant, to a point of deciding the outcome in some theatres. Over a million Indians participated in the first one, serving in Europe, the Mediterranean, West Asia and Africa. The bicycle troops in Somme and the turbaned ones entering through the Jaffa Gate in Jerusalem are among the iconic images of that era. But it is only in recent years that the valour and sacrifice of these soldiers has entered public consciousness. Unburdened by agendas, PM Modi set the record straight and honoured them at memorials like Neuve Chapelle and Haifa. Our public naturally then began to take notice. Initiatives are now underway to create historical trails of the campaigns of our servicemen abroad.

This applies in equal measure to the Second World War, when as many as two-and-a-half million Indians took up arms. In this case, the contribution was notable on both sides, with the Netaji-led Indian National Army firing up the cause of freedom. It also extended to major logistical efforts. Countries like China and Russia were kept supplied through the Himalayan hump and the Persian corridor respectively. When an Indian military contingent marched through the Red Square in Moscow in June 2020, this was a reminder of India's contribution to the eventual victory. The stabilizing role that the Indian armed forces played from East and Southeast Asia to West Asia and Europe in the aftermath of the Second World War is no less notable.

It is this tradition of global service that became the foundation for the country to emerge as a leader in UN Peacekeeping Operations. From that, India has now evolved into an effective first responder in regional crisis